

1–3 Union Square West

Stone Palimpsest at the Broken Angle: An Architectural Exegesis of 1–3 Union Square West

Every previously italicized phrase is highlighted and colour-coded by source. Where the source page is on file, clicking the highlight opens the scan.

COLOUR KEY — ONE COLOUR PER SOURCE · sources with a page scan are marked ↗

■ Stern, <i>New York</i> 1880, 1999 p. 442 (4) ↗	■ Sackersdorff, <i>1815 Blue Book</i> p. 3 (1) ↗
■ Spielvogel, <i>The Landmarks of New York</i> , 2016 p. 346 (18) ↗	■ Postal & Dolkart, <i>Guide to New York City Landmarks</i> , 2009 p. 76 (4) ↗
■ LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890 p. 1 (39) ↗	■ AIA, <i>AIA Edition 3</i> , 1988 p. 186 (1) ↗
■ Wolfe, <i>New York 15 Walking Tours</i> , 2003 p. 251 (1) ↗	■ Bromley, <i>1897 Bromleys Atlas</i> p. 19 (2) ↗
■ G W Bromley & Co, <i>1916 Atlas of the Borough of Manhattan</i> p. 54 (1) ↗	■ Bromley, <i>1930 Land Book of the Borough of Manhattan</i> p. 53 (1) ↗
■ Bromley, <i>1955 Manhattan Land Book</i> p. 43 (2) ↗	■ Hennessy, <i>Walking Broadway</i> , 2020 p. 97 (4) ↗
■ Stern, <i>New York</i> 2000, 2006 p. 377 (2) ↗	

PREFACE

Where the diagonal insurgency of Broadway transgresses the orthogonal decorum of East Fourteenth Street, there accretes a monument whose consequence is less material than epistemic — a fabric prized not for the sum of its stones but for the historical caesura it renders visible. So imposing was its presence to the eyes of its contemporaries that the most exalted encomium they could muster was to pronounce it *(as substantial as any office building downtown)*, anchoring it in perpetuity at *(the northwest corner of Fourteenth Street and Broadway (Union Square West))*. It stands, in the deepest sense, as a lithic chrysalis, suspended in the very act of transfiguration between the twilight of the bearing wall and the dawn of the emancipated steel cage — a threshold organism whose ambivalence is its glory.

I. FROM CARTOGRAPHIC VOID TO CORNER APOTHEOSIS

The chronicle commences in privation. Where masonry now aspires, the earliest surveyors could conscript nothing whatever into their ledgers, registering only that there subsisted *(reference to 0 structures)* upon the parcel — a tabula rasa awaiting the summons of its destiny. The very ground was an artifact of the draughtsman's imagination, conjured out of the grid's implacable geometry: it was the *(acute angle where Bloomingdale Road (now Broadway) intersected the bowery)* that quarried this orphaned lozenge of earth, a fragment men first *(dubbed Union Place)*. What debuted as interstitial and disreputable terrain — a precinct where, at the outset, *(the poor built shanties there)* — was progressively disciplined by the machinery of civic

order until, ere the 1830s had expired, the square stood *(graded, paved, and fenced in)* and consecrated to the choreography of *(military and civic parades and festivities)*. Refinement trailed regulation as inevitably as shadow trails the gnomon, and presently *(mansions had sprung up around the picturesque square)*. Yet this patrician interlude proved evanescent; the vertical avarice of the metropolis could ill abide so coveted a corner, and within a single generation *(tall commercial buildings, like the nine-story Lincoln, replaced the mansions)*, borne aloft upon the inexorable migration of capital and ambition ever *(northward)*.

II. THE TECTONIC PREDICAMENT AND THE ONTOLOGY OF THE SKYSCRAPER

It is here that the edifice divulges its true magnitude, for it is a chimerical body, its ferrous interior armature laboring in confederacy with — and never in abdication of — its lithic perimeter. This is precisely the uneasy concord of *(metal-skeleton interior construction with masonry-bearing walls)* that constitutes it a paradigmatic instance of *(a transitional phase in skyscraper construction)*. The threshold it courts yet declines to transgress is drawn with taxonomic severity, for the very crucible of the authentic tall building resides in *(the replacement of load-bearing walls with a steel skeleton that provides all of the structural support)* — a manumission the Lincoln, for all its aspiration, has yet to attain. Its walls persist in an unrepentant corporeality, their gravitational travail inscribed without dissimulation upon the epidermis of the façade, so that even as its *(Romanesque Revival arcades articulate the skeletal construction)* within, the *(massiveness of the walls is evident)* without, and the antediluvian horizontality of coursed masonry is reiterated, insisted upon, by *(the stacked fenestration)*. The gaze is thereby conducted laterally, along the breadth, rather than propelled vertiginously toward the apex — an unmistakable idiom of the pre-ferric sensibility. The engineers' verdict ratifies the reading of the aesthete: this is a fabric that *(marks an important transitional phase in skyscraper engineering)*, an assemblage compacted of *(metal framing in combination with traditional masonry bearing walls)*.

III. COMPOSITIONAL GOVERNANCE AND THE TRIBUNAL OF CONTEMPORARY TASTE

The elevation submits itself to the venerable canon of the *(Tripartite Typology)* — that transposition of base, shaft, and capital from the columnar order onto the anatomy of the commercial block. Yet the architect's disposition invited reproof in its own hour, for in lieu of subordinating his surface to a single sovereign motif he elected to proliferate *(many layers of motifs rather than a dominant arcade)*, an accretive superfluity his critics could not forgive. The censure of the Record and Guide remains lacerating in its precision: the work betrayed *(a wandering, hesitating air about it as though the architect could not hit upon the right word for his idea and took refuge in redundancy)*. But what the disciplinarians of the nineteenth century arraigned as redundancy, the modern sensibility absolves as opulence — a palimpsest of *(Layered Arcades)* heaped stratum upon stratum, luxuriant precisely where a chaster composition would subside into abstinence.

IV. THE CLADDING AND THE CHROMATIC ARGUMENT

The wall constitutes a deliberately polyphonic masonry ensemble, for the edifice stands *(Sheathed in Indiana limestone, granite, and brick)* and profligate with *(exceptional details)* all *(carved in terra cotta)*. The governing dialect is unswervingly and unapologetically *(Romanesque-Revival)*, and its coloration enacts a subtle atmospheric perspective wrought not in pigment but in the very substance of the stone — ascending from a warm, chthonic base of *(Tumbleweed - 222 166 131)* toward a pallid, empyreal crown of *(Pearl White - 238 235 218)*, the terrestrial ceding to the celestial as the eye climbs. The plinth reposes upon *(Indiana Limestone)* and indurates at the pavement into *(Granite Bulkheads)*, the igneous stone judiciously reserved for those thresholds where the abrasion of the city grinds most mercilessly; aloft, the envelope perseveres in *(Indiana Limestone)* tempered with *(Terra Cotta)* and *(Light Brick)*. Most eloquent of all is the dialectic of surfaces, the calculated antiphony of *(Smooth and Rock Faced Indiana Limestone)* — the rusticated coarseness conferring a quarried, geological gravitas, the dressed plane furnishing the burnished foil against which each incision of carved ornament may register with lapidary clarity.

V. THE PORTAL AND ITS RECONCILED IDIOMS

The threshold proclaims itself a composition of *(4 Bays)*, presided over by a deeply modeled *(Round Arch)* — that semicircular figure which is the very syntax of the revival — vaulting from *(Engaged Columns)* foundered half within the wall's own body. Its archivolt effects a rapprochement between two estranged tongues: the antique, phytomorphic involutions of *(Acanthus Scrolls)* set in studied antithesis against the barbaric, glinting chevron of the *(Norman Zigzag Molding)*, the botanical and the geometric espoused within the compass of a single arc.

VI. THE FENESTRATION AND THE ARCADED MID-BODY

The apertures ascend beneath a *(Double Height Arcade)*, each opening *(Arched)* with a nave-like, liturgical cadence, its curvature masoned of *(Limestone Voussoirs)* whose radiating joints publish the compressive rectitude of the arch to all who care to read them. These are sustained upon *(Byzantine Columns)* surmounted by *(Byzantine Capitals)* — those deeply undercut, textile-dense baskets of Constantinopolitan descent, encrusted with an all-over interlace. Interposed between the arches, the *(Foliated Spandrels)* effloresce in low relief; the openings are ennobled by *(Molded Enframements)* and steadied at their imposts by *(Corbels)* that appear, bracket-wise, to receive and redistribute the burden of the stone above.

VII. THE ICONOGRAPHIC AND SCULPTURAL PROGRAM

Across pier and spandrel there roves a bestiary of exceptional refinement. Preeminent among its creatures is the *(Griffin)*, the leonine-aquiline chimera pressed into the service of mercantile heraldry, coursing amid ribbons of *(Acanthus Scrolls)* and constellations of *(Byzantine Capitals)* seated upon the *(Limestone Piers)* that govern the vertical armature. Most arresting is the mute congregation of *(Human Heads)* and *(Lion Heads)* — visages that emerge from the masonry in the immemorial manner of the medieval label-stop, at once ornament and structural annunciation, delight and admonition.

VIII. THE ROOFLINE AND THE TERMINATING CORNICE: THE DIADEM

The entire ascension is resolved in a boldly *(Projecting Cornice)*, thrust from the wall's plane to inscribe a stratum of profound shadow against the firmament. Its supreme distinction — the feature graven upon the memory of every passerby — is that improbable fenestrated frieze, most felicitously rendered by the peripatetic observer as *(a cornice of 40 little windows with interstitial paired columns)*, a dwarf gallery conferring upon the crown its Lombard-Romanesque solemnity; and hence the guidebooks enjoin, with laconic sufficiency, to *(Note the multiwindow cornice)*. Beneath it there cascades an entire litany of enrichment: a *(Band of Bosses)*, the load-receiving *(Human/Lion Corbels)*, the plaited and medallioned ribbon of the *(Byzantine Guilloche)*, colonnettes wrung into helical, solomonic torsion as *(Paired Spiral Columns)*, a serried row of *(Dentils)*, shadow-hoarding *(Recessed Panels)*, the convex quarter-round sweep of the *(Ovolo Molding)*, and — crowning the whole, and returning at the summit to the very theme first intoned far below at the portal — a valedictory *(Acanthus Scroll Band)*.

IX. THE FABRIC ACROSS THE LONGUE DURÉE

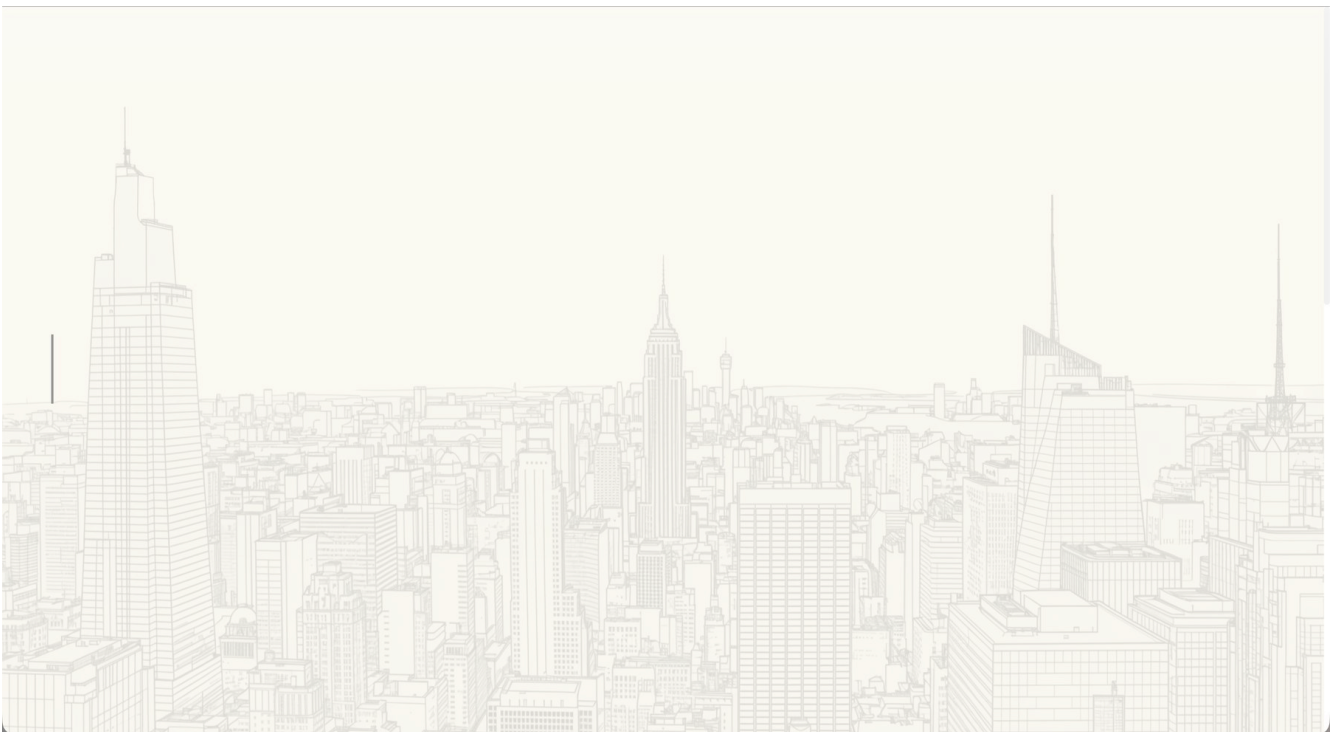
The cadastral atlases chronicle the edifice's gradual coalescence with dispassionate fidelity. By the century's terminus the antecedent trio of dwellings had fused beneath a single appellation, the surveyor now consigning to the record a solitary *(Brick building with Stone front)* denominated simply the *(Lincoln Bldg')*. The name endured into the new century, though the ledgers, with curious parsimony, then reckoned it a mere *(3 Story Brick building with Store and Elevators)*. In the interbellum interval its authentic stature was at last avowed — a *(10 Story Brick building with Store and Elevators)* — and by mid-century it persevered, unmistakable, as the *(LINCOLN BLDG')*, catalogued as a *(10 Story Brick or Stone or Concrete building with Store and Elevators)*. More than a century onward, the weathered fabric was ministered to anew when, in the closing months of 2015, the municipality sanctioned both *(facade repairs and roof replacement)* — the twin sacraments most indispensable to a masonry envelope of such antiquity and ornamental congestion.

X. THE COLLOQUY OF NEIGHBORS AND THE CHARGED STREETSCAPE

The edifice sustains a colloquy with its confrères along the western flank of the square, foremost among them the structure immediately to its north, so that the block presents *(two solid and accomplished historic structures)* in reciprocal discourse. The two are consanguineous kin yet estranged in dialect: they *(share many compositional details)*, and yet where one architect elected *(a classical vocabulary)*, the other *(embraced the Romanesque)*. Recognition as a monument arrived not upon the wings of reverence but under the shadow of the wrecking-ball, for it was *(concerns about the fate of historic buildings on other sites around the square)* that ultimately precipitated *(the designation as landmarks)* — a defensive canonization wrung from anxiety rather than tendered in homage.

XI. CODA

The edifice is, in the final adjudication, a masterwork of the liminal instant, enduring within the canon precisely because it stands *(representative of the early skyscraper form as it evolved in New York)*, where its makers, in the historians' phrasing, contrived *(to adapt already-popular styles to this new building type)*. Its two-score diminutive windows and their coupled colonnettes crown a structure that is at once a document of engineering's evolution and a bravura oration in polychrome masonry — a Romanesque essay of the loftiest order, keeping its perpetual vigil where the great square shatters against the axis of Fourteenth Street.



CITATION CHART

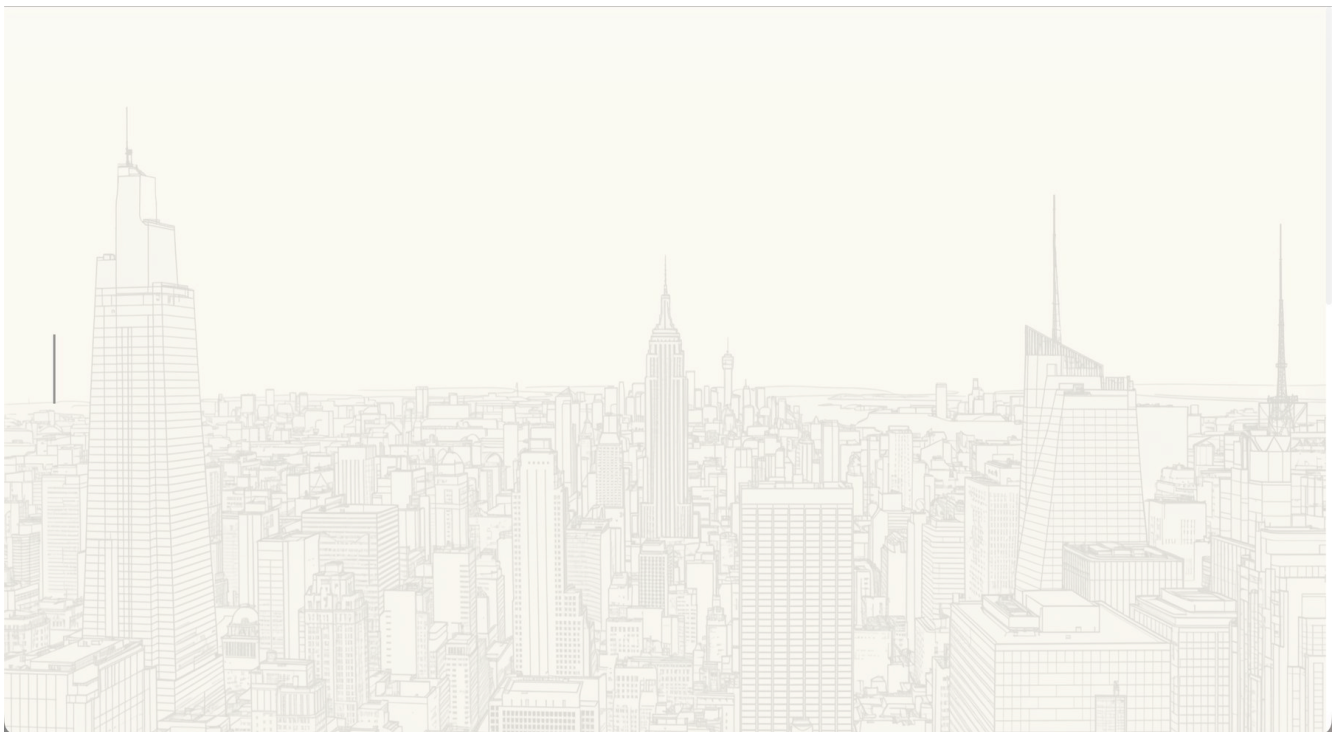
Every highlighted quote, in order of appearance, correlated to its underlying source. The swatch matches the highlight colour in the text.

#	Verbatim Quote (abbreviated)	Source (Author, Title, Year, Page)
1	"as substantial as any office building downtown"	 Stern, <i>New York 1880</i> , 1999, p. 442 [page scan]
2	"the northwest corner of Fourteenth Street and Broadway (Union Square West)"	 Stern, <i>New York 1880</i> , 1999, p. 442 [page scan]
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11	"northward"	 Spielvogel, <i>The Landmarks of New York</i> , 2016, p. 346 [page scan]
12	"metal-skeleton interior construction with masonry-bearing walls"	 Spielvogel, <i>The Landmarks of New York</i> , 2016, p. 346 [page scan]
13	"a transitional phase in skyscraper construction"	 Spielvogel, <i>The Landmarks of New York</i> , 2016, p. 346 [page scan]
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19	"metal framing in combination with traditional masonry bearing walls"	 Postal & Dolkart, <i>Guide to New York City Landmarks</i> , 2009, p. 76 [page scan]
20	"Tripartite Typology"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
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27	"Romanesque-Revival"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
28	"Tumbleweed - 222 166 131"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
29	"Pearl White - 238 235 218"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
30	"Indiana Limestone"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
31	"Granite Bulkheads"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
32	"Indiana Limestone"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
33	"Terra Cotta"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
34	"Light Brick"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
35	"Smooth and Rock Faced Indiana Limestone"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
36	"4 Bays"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
37	"Round Arch"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
38	"Engaged Columns"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
39	"Acanthus Scrolls"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
40	"Norman Zigzag Molding"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
41	"Double Height Arcade"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
42	"Arched"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
43	"Limestone Voussoirs"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]

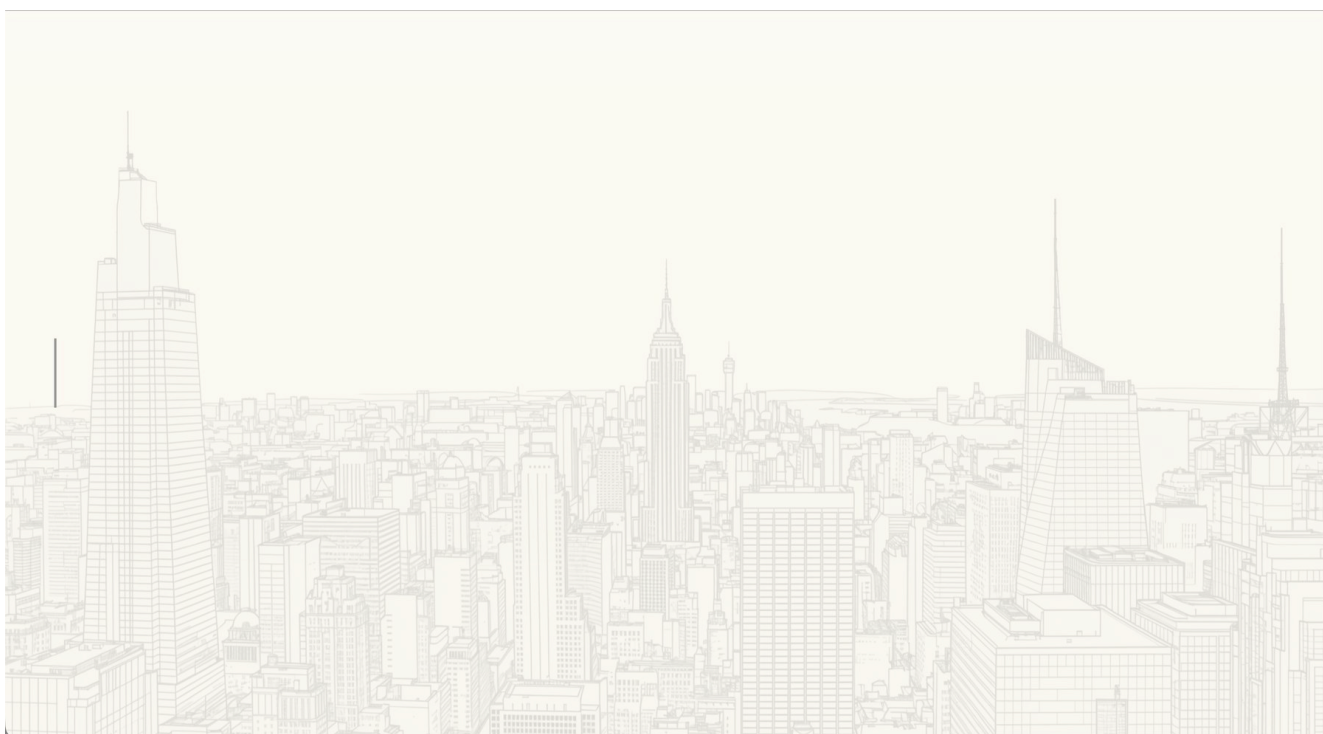
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44	"Byzantine Columns"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
45	"Byzantine Capitals"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
46	"Foliated Spandrels"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
47	"Molded Enframements"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
48	"Corbels"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
49	"Griffin"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
50	"Acanthus Scrolls"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
51	"Byzantine Capitals"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
52	"Limestone Piers"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
53	"Human Heads"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
54	"Lion Heads"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
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59	"Human/Lion Corbels"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
60	"Byzantine Guilloche"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
61	"Paired Spiral Columns"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
62	"Dentils"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
63	"Recessed Panels"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
64	"Ovolo Molding"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
65	"Acanthus Scroll Band"	 LPC, <i>Union Square</i> , 1890, p. 1 [page scan]
66	"Brick building with Stone front"	 Bromley, <i>1897 Bromleys Atlas</i> , p. 19 [page scan]
67	"'Lincoln Bldg'"	 Bromley, <i>1897 Bromleys Atlas</i> , p. 19 [page scan]
68	"3 Story Brick building with Store and Elevators"	 G W Bromley & Co, <i>1916 Atlas of the Borough of Manhattan</i> , p. 54 [page scan]
69	"10 Story Brick building with Store and Elevators"	 Bromley, <i>1930 Land Book of the Borough of Manhattan</i> , p. 53 [page scan]
70	"'LINCOLN BLDG'"	 Bromley, <i>1955 Manhattan Land Book</i> , p. 43 [page scan]
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78	"the designation as landmarks"	 Stern, <i>New York 2000</i> , 2006, p. 377 [page scan]
79	"representative of the early skyscraper form as it evolved in New York"	 Postal & Dolkart, <i>Guide to New York City Landmarks</i> , 2009, p. 76 [page scan]
80	"to adapt already-popular styles to this new building type"	 Postal & Dolkart, <i>Guide to New York City Landmarks</i> , 2009, p. 76 [page scan]



SOURCE PAGES

13 scanned pages, one per cited source page. Each lists the highlighted quotes drawn from it.



Stern, *New York* 1880, 1999, p. 442

Quotes drawn from this page: 1 2 21 22





753 Broadway, southwest corner of East Eighth Street. J. Morgan Slade, 1880. View to the southwest. LAA. CU.

fact, architects seemed to have been pushed to a higher level of creativity than was typical in downtown buildings, perhaps because of the need for these new structures to fit in with a still fashionable residential neighborhood that was also home to the city's most exclusive shops. At the time of its completion, Griffith Thomas's Domestic Sewing Machine Company Building (1872-73), at the southwest corner of Broadway and Fourteenth Street, was the city's tallest, at 110 feet.¹⁸⁸ Given its prominent location in a still mostly residential area, it stood out as a monument. Thomas's design, consisting of five stories plus an inhabited mansard, was very Parisian, with its pronounced corner tower rising to a steep segmented dome. In contrast, J. Morgan Slade's five-story 753 Broadway (1880), at the southwest corner of Eighth Street, was a severely detailed three-by-five-bay brick and iron cube.¹⁸⁹ William Schickel's Century Company Building (1880-81), facing Union Square at 33 East Seventeenth Street, between Broadway and Fourth Avenue, developed as a speculative venture by the dry-goods company Arnold Constable, was principally leased by the company that gave the building its name, the publishers of the popular *Century Magazine* as well as *St. Nicholas Magazine*, which was written for children.¹⁹⁰ The Century Building was also home to



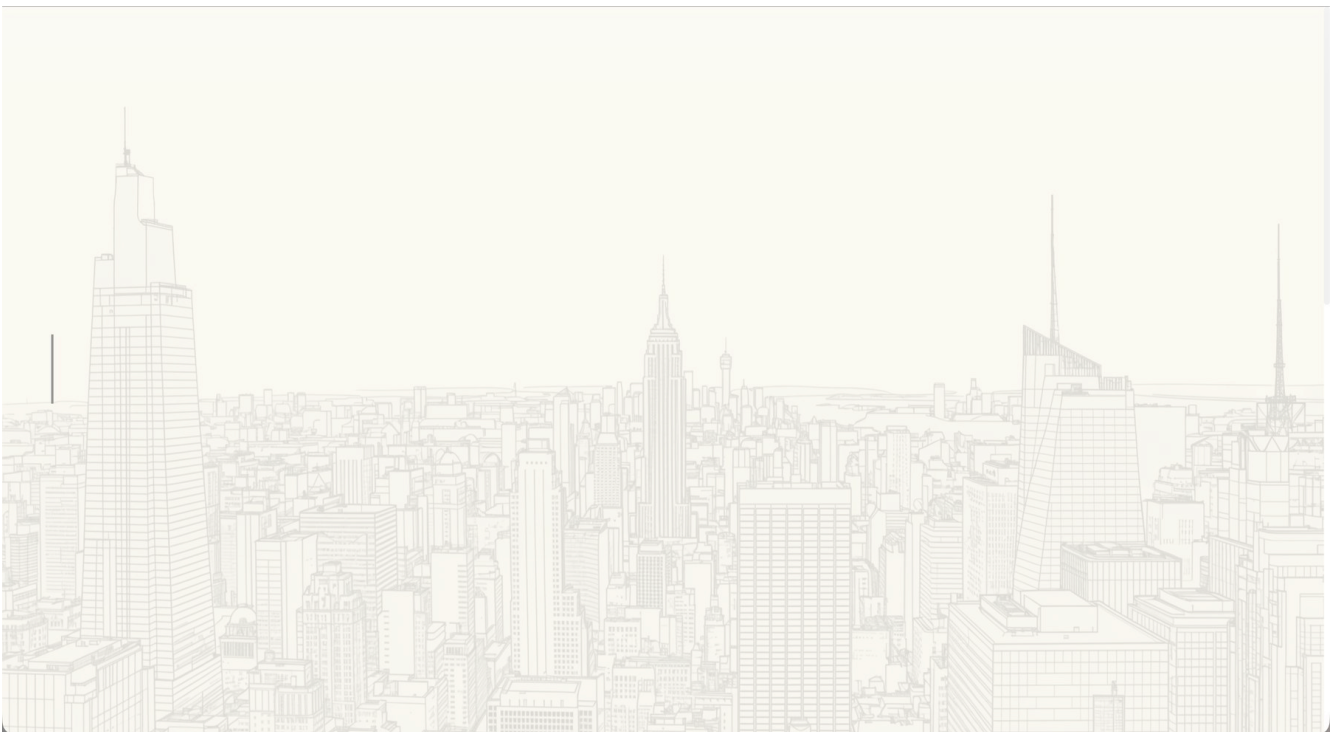
Lincoln Building, northwest corner of Broadway and East Fourteenth Street. R. H. Robertson, 1885. View to the northwest. AR. CU.

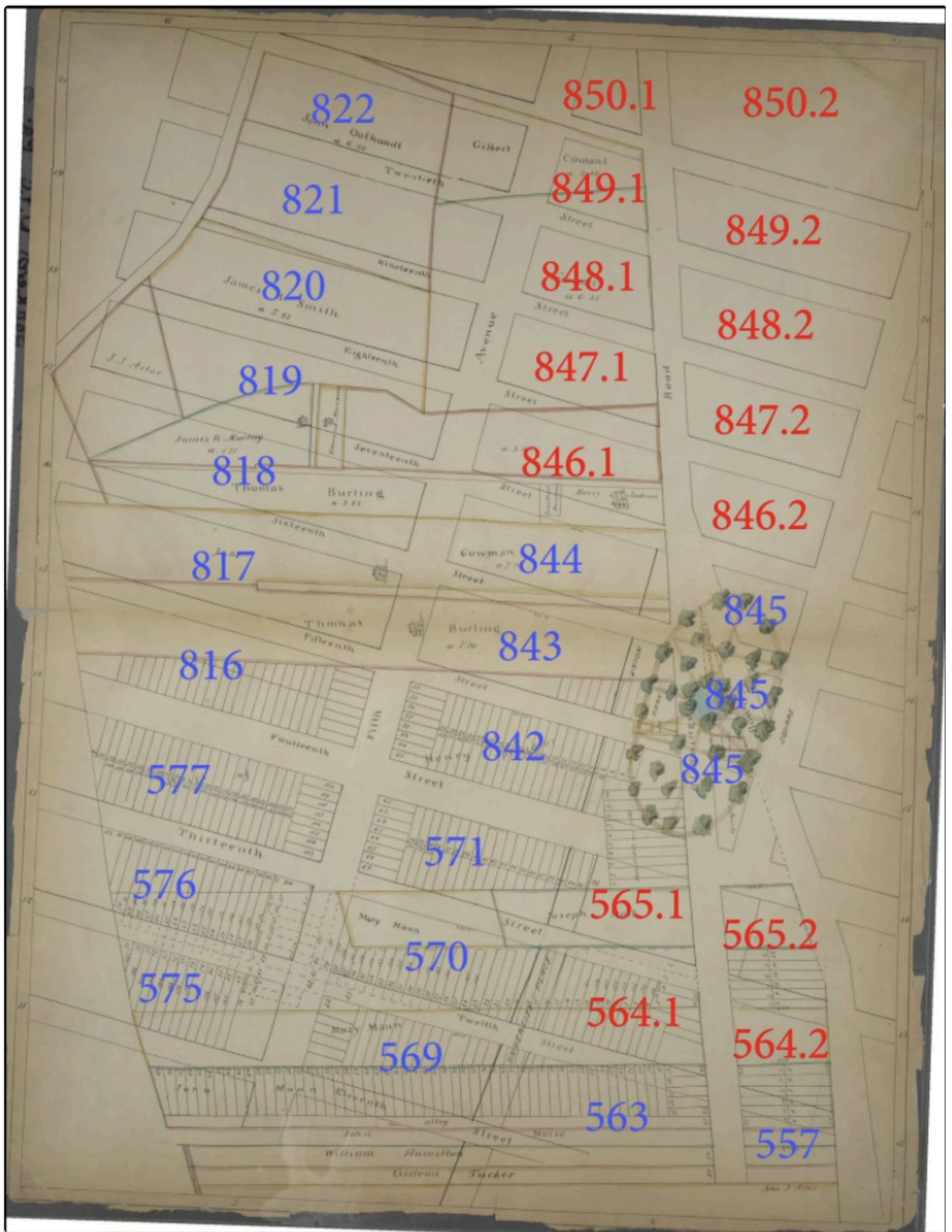


McIntyre Building, northeast corner of Broadway and East Eighteenth Street. R. H. Robertson, 1890-92. View to the northeast. King, 1893. CU.

Sackersdorff, 1815 *Blue Book*, p. 3

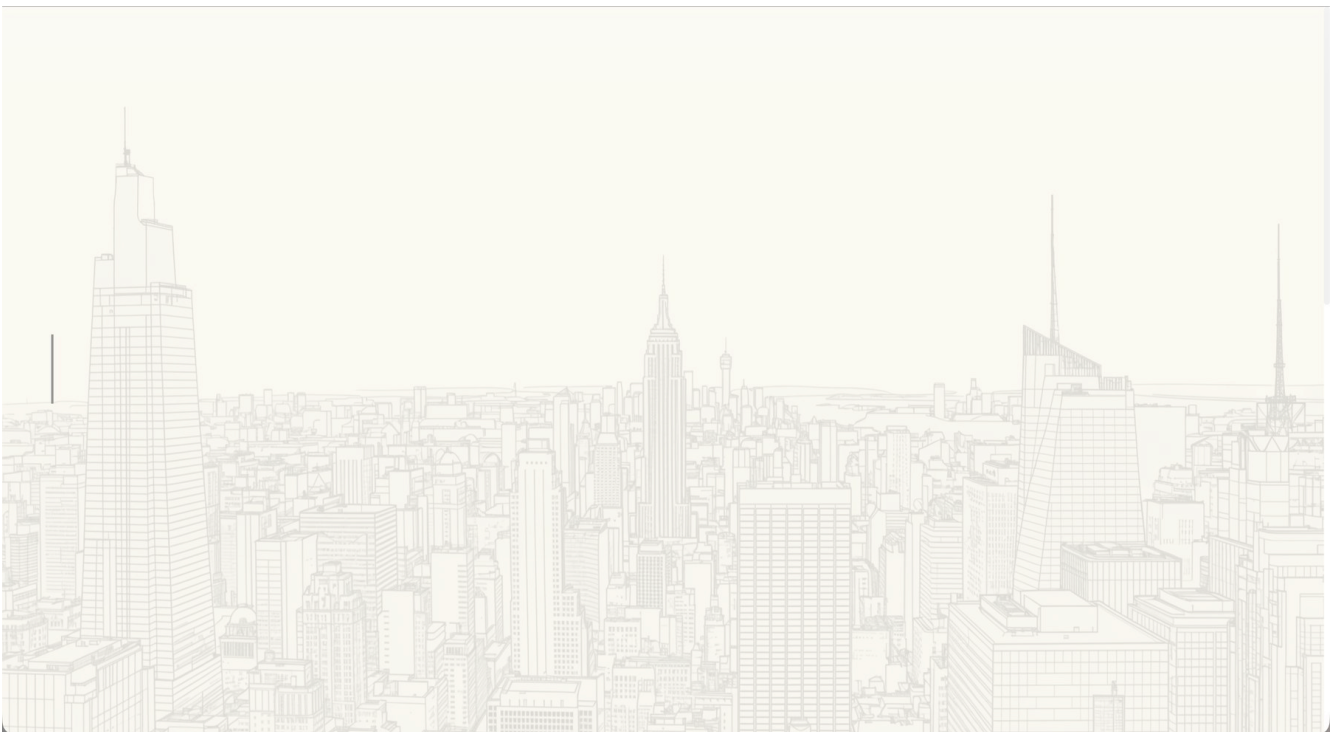
Quotes drawn from this page: 3





Spielvogel, *The Landmarks of New York*, 2016, p. 346

Quotes drawn from this page: 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 24 25 26 72





CHARLES A. VISSANI HOUSE

priests who lived there; it even contained a chapel. Vissani had been appointed the first Commissary General of the Holy Land for the United States in 1880. The main tasks of the Commissariat—which moved to Washington, D.C., in 1889 and is still in operation today—are to increase public awareness about the holy places of Jerusalem and to preserve and recover the sanctuaries of Palestine.

Since 1946, the property has been used as a multiunit residence, with additional units created in 1969. Nevertheless, the building's ecclesiastical overtones, heightened by pointed and ogee arches, pinnacles, trefoils, drip moldings, and lush foliated tympana, serve as an imposing reminder of its original mission.



LINCOLN BUILDING

LINCOLN BUILDING

1889–90; 2015–

1–3 UNION SQUARE WEST, MANHATTAN

ARCHITECT: R.H. ROBERTSON;
RESTORATION, WALTER B. MELVIN
ARCHITECTS

DESIGNATED: JULY 12, 1988

When the Commissioners Map of 1807–11 first laid out Manhattan's grid plan, the acute angle where Bloomingdale Road (now Broadway) intersected the Bowery at 16th Street demarcated an island of land that was dubbed Union Place. Initially, the poor built shanties there, but by 1839, Union Square (as it came to be known) had been graded, paved, and fenced in, and it was set aside for military and civic parades and festivities. By the 1850s,

mansions had sprung up around the picturesque square. Within a few decades, tall commercial buildings, like the nine-story Lincoln, replaced the mansions as the city grew northward.

Combining metal-skeleton interior construction with masonry-bearing walls, the Lincoln represents a transitional phase in skyscraper construction. The essential criterion of a true skyscraper is the replacement of load-bearing walls with a steel skeleton that provides all of the structural support. In the Lincoln Building, Romanesque Revival arcades articulate the skeletal construction, although the massiveness of the walls is evident, and the horizontality of traditional masonry is further emphasized by the stacked fenestration. Sheathed in Indiana limestone, granite, and brick, the building is ornamented with exceptional details: acanthus scrolls, Byzantine capitals, griffins, and human and lion heads, all carved in terra cotta. In late 2015, plans were approved by the NYC Department of Buildings for façade repairs and roof replacement.

NORWOOD NEWS, FORMERLY WILLIAMSBRIDGE RESERVOIR KEEPER'S HOUSE

1889–90; 1998

3400 RESERVOIR OVAL (ALSO KNOWN AS 3450 PUTNAM PLACE), THE BRONX

ARCHITECT: GEORGE W. BIRDSALL, CHIEF ENGINEER, CROTON AQUEDUCT, FOR NEW YORK CITY DEPARTMENT OF PUBLIC WORKS

DESIGNATED: FEBRUARY 8, 2000

The Reservoir Keeper's House is the only remaining building in New York City from the Bronx and Byram Rivers



Postal & Dolkart, *Guide to New York City Landmarks*, 2009, p. 76

Quotes drawn from this page: 18 19 79 80



MANHATTAN

was designed to attract the attention of riders on the Sixth Avenue Elevated, which ran in front of the building.

195 **5, 7, 9, 17, 19, 21, and 23 West 16th Street** (c. 1845–46), designated individually 1990. In the 1840s the streets adjacent to Fifth Avenue just north of 14th Street were developed with row houses. Most of these structures were demolished as commerce invaded the area in the late 19th century, but West 16th Street retains a significant number of Greek Revival houses. The most impressive are the four survivors of a row of nine wide houses—Nos. 5, 7, 9, and 17—each of which has a full-height curving bay on its front facade, an extremely rare feature in New York. In 1930 the family-planning pioneer Margaret Sanger moved her Birth Control Clinical Research Bureau into No. 17. Nos. 19 and 21 are simpler houses displaying fine ironwork, while No. 23 has a magnificent cast-iron balcony and stoop railing. All the houses have wide stone entrance enframements with battered sides and eared corners; this is a classic Greek form copied from the window surrounds on Greek temples.

197 **Lincoln Building, 1–3 Union Square West** (R. H. Robertson, 1889–90), designated 1988. The Lincoln Building is representative of the early skyscraper form as it evolved in New York, where architects chose to adapt already-popular styles to this new building type. Robertson designed the Lincoln Building in the same Romanesque Revival style that he used for churches, houses, and other structures. The building, faced in limestone, granite, red brick, and terra cotta, marks an important transitional phase in skyscraper engineering: it was constructed with a metal framing in combination with traditional masonry bearing walls.

198 **Bank of the Metropolis, 31 Union Square West** (Bruce Price, 1902–03), designated 1988. Price was an important early skyscraper designer with a particular interest in adapting the tripartite form of the column to tall buildings. This neo-Renaissance limestone-faced example is clearly massed in Price's preferred base-shaft-capital manner. The Bank of the Metropolis, founded in 1871 to serve the needs of businesses in the Union Square area, maintained its offices on the square until 1918, when it was absorbed by the Bank of Manhattan.

199 **Decker Building, now the Union Building, 33 Union Square West** (John Edelmann in the employ of Alfred Zucker, 1892–93), designated 1988. A rare example of a Moorish-inspired skyscraper, the headquarters of the

Decker Piano Company was designed by John Edelmann, mentor and friend of Louis Sullivan. Many features of the Decker Building, most notably the naturalistic ornament, reflect Sullivan's influence. Between 1968 and 1974 Andy Warhol's Factory occupied the sixth floor. The base was handsomely restored in 1995.

200 **Century Building, now Barnes & Noble Bookstore, 33 East 17th Street** (William Schickel, 1880–81), designated 1986. The red brick Century Building is a rare New York example of a Queen Anne-style commercial structure. Erected to house the prestigious Century Publishing Company, publisher of *The Century* and *St. Nicholas* magazines, the building is characteristic of the finest Queen Anne design in its free use of classical motifs in stone and terra cotta and its employment of the style's trademark sunflowers. After standing vacant for many years, the building was converted into a bookstore, and the facade received an award-winning restoration.

201 **Everett Building, 200 Park Avenue South** (Goldwin Starrett & Van Vleck, 1908), designated 1988. Located on the north side of Union Square, the Everett Building exemplifies an important development in the design of commercial high-rise buildings—the construction of functional, fireproof structures with large windows, open floor space, and simple classical detail. This emphasis on functionalism reflects the influence of Chicago skyscraper designs; in fact, the architect, Goldwin Starrett, had worked for four years in the Chicago office of Daniel Burnham.

202 **Gorham Manufacturing Company Building, 889–891 Broadway** (Edward Hale Kendall, 1883–84; alteration, John H. Duncan, 1912), designated 1984. This commercial building in the Queen Anne style was erected for the Gorham Manufacturing Company, a leading American silver firm, for its retail outlet in the exclusive Ladies' Mile shopping district. The Gorham is an early example of a mixed-use building: only the lower two floors were occupied by the store; the upper floors were rented as bachelor apartments. By 1893, however, the building was entirely in commercial use. The architect John H. Duncan is responsible for a remodeling of the building in 1912 that entailed the removal of a corner tower and the addition of roof dormers. The building now contains shops at street level and apartments above.

203 **Lord & Taylor Store, 901 Broadway** (James H. Giles, 1869–70), designated 1977. Two English immigrants, Samuel Lord and George Taylor, founded the dry goods firm

LPC, *Union Square, 1890*, p. 1

Quotes drawn from this page: 20 23 27 28 29 30 31 32 33 34 35 36 37 38 39 40 41 42 43 44 45
46 47 48 49 50 51 52 53 54 55 58 59 60 61 62 63 64 65



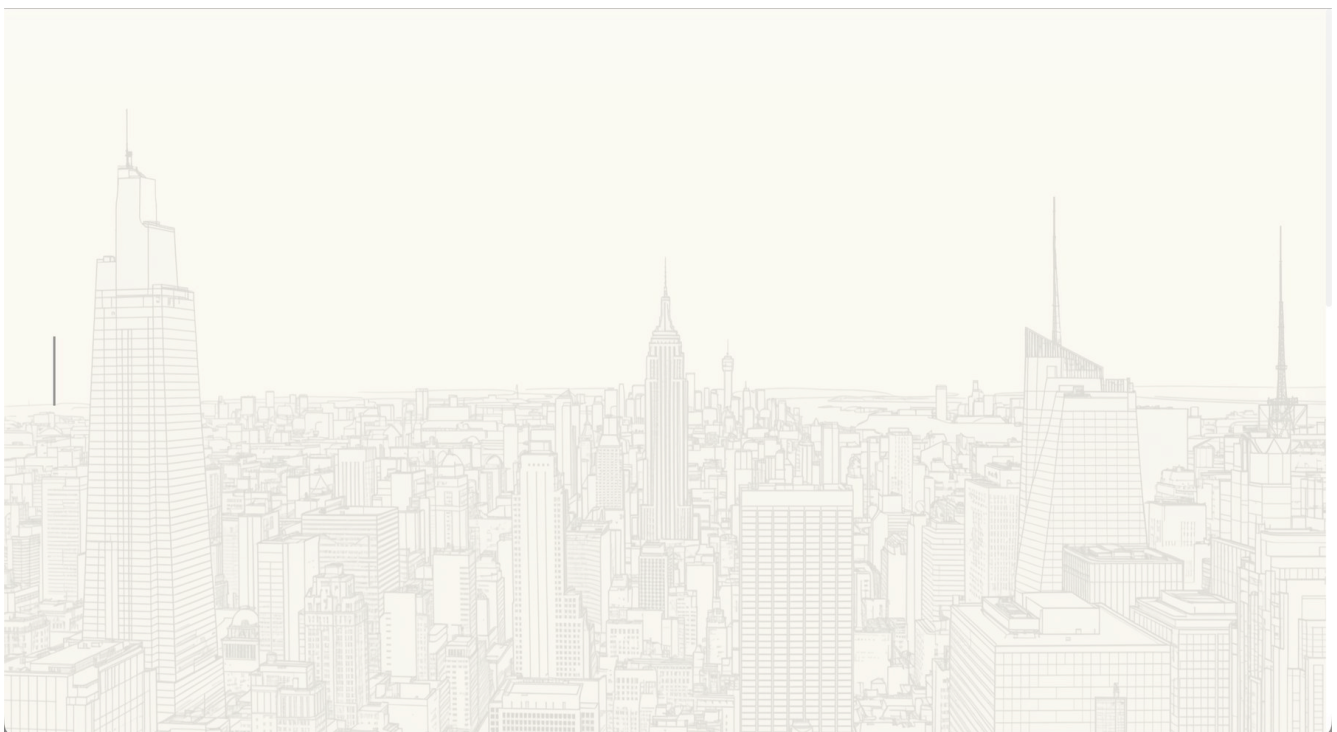
"<Architecture Style>_Romanesque-Revival, <Base Color>_Tumbleweed - 222 166 131, <Façade Color>_Pearl White - 238 235 218, <Base Material>_Indiana Limestone, Granite Bulkheads, <Façade Material>_Indiana Limestone, Terra Cotta, Light Brick, <Entrance Description>_4 Bays, Round Arch, Engaged Columns, Acanthus Scrolls, Norman Zigzag Molding, <Window Detail>_Double Height Arcade, Arched, Byzantine Columns, Foliated Spandrels, Corbels, Limestone Voussoirs, Molded Enframements, <Brickwork Style>_Smooth and Rock Faced Indiana Limestone, Layered Arcades, Griffin, Acanthus Scrolls, Byzantine Capitals, Human Heads, Lion Heads, Limestone Piers, Tripartite Typology, <Roofline Description>_Projecting Cornice, Band of Bosses, Human/Lion Corbels, Byzantine Guilloche, Paired Spiral Columns, Dentils, Recessed Panels, Ovolo Molding, Acanthus Scroll Band."

mentioned as: 1-3 Union Square west

[View Document Image](#)

AIA, *AIA Edition 3*, 1988, p. 186

Quotes drawn from this page: 56





[W 3.] **American Savings Bank/originally Union Square Savings Bank**, 20 Union Sq. E., NE cor. E. 15th St. 1924. Henry Bacon.

A classy **Corinthian colonnade** is somewhat forlorn in these precincts. **Bacon's** best remembrance is the **Lincoln Memorial**.



[W 4a.] **Guardian Life Insurance Company/originally Germania Life Insurance Company**, 201 Park Ave. S., NE cor. E. 17th St. 1911. D'Oench & Yost. [W 4b.] **Annex**, 105 E. 17th St., bet. Park Ave. S. and Irving Place. 1961. Skidmore, Owings & Merrill.

The **mansarded** bulk of this **Renaissance Revival** marvel is best seen from a distance, down 17th Street or from the adjacent Union Square Park. **Germania Life** was a name that became an onerous millstone at the advent of World War I. The board of directors agreed to rename it, picking a name with the largest number of reusable letters that they could find. **Guardian** still crowns the roof against its mansard backdrop.

Next door is the sleek annex, a simple grid of **aluminum and glass** infilled behind with white vertical blinds. As an accessory, it is a graceful annex to the proud parent, unabashedly "modern," an articulated annex.



[W 2.] Zeckendorf Towers (apts.)



[W 5.] Century Building at Union Sq.



[W 5.] Originally **The Century Building**, 33 E. 17th St., bet. Park Ave. S. and Broadway to W. 18th St. 1881. William Schickel. ★

This red brick and whitestone charmer is where the popular Cen-

tury magazine (for grown-ups) and **St. Nicholas** (for boys and girls) were published before the century turned.

[W 6.] 31 Union Square West/originally Bank of the Metropolis Building, NW cor. 16th St. 1903. Bruce Price.

An early and unwitting **sliver building**, this neo-Renaissance slab now houses a restaurant in its original banking rooms, a place for **SUPERMAN'S** lunch.

[W 7.] Originally Lincoln Building, 1 Union Sq. W., NW cor. E. 14th St. 1890. R. H. Robertson

Romanesque Revival granite crowned with a cornice of **40** little windows with interstitial paired columns.

[W 8.] Originally YWCA (Young Women's Christian Association)/formerly Rand School, 7 E. 15th St., bet. Union Sq. W. and Fifth Ave. ca. 1889. R. H. Robertson.

Romanesque Revival in granite, brick, and brownstone. The grand bay windows give the entrance portal a stronger stature.



[W 9a.] Sidney Hillman Health Center/originally Margaret Louisa Home, YWCA (lodging house), 16 E. 16th St., bet. Union Sq. W. and Fifth Ave. 1890. R. H. Robertson.



of Liberty, Bartholdi offered the Lafayette statue as a token of French friendship with the American people in gratitude for their sympathy during the Franco-Prussian War. Lafayette, although an aristocrat, was sympathetic with the cause of the American Revolution and served as a Major General in the Continental Army. The pedestal is designed to resemble a ship's prow. 870.1

Facing Union Square between 14th and 15th streets is massive **Zeckendorf Towers** (Davis Brody & Assocs., William Zeckendorf, Jr., developer, 1987), a 670-unit condominium in four 29-story towers, topped by open framework pyramids. The towers are set on a seven-story base that fills a triangular plot while maintaining the orientation to the city street grid. Original plans called for much taller structures, but fierce community opposition forced the developer to scale them down, thus reducing the "darkening and overwhelming" effect on the park below and respecting Union Square's surroundings. The lower floors include retail establishments and also Beth Israel Medical Center facilities. At the very corner of the building at 14th Street was **Joe's Saloon**, rendered immortal by habitué Hugh A. D'Arcy, who, in 1887, penned the sentimental ballad *The Face on the Barroom Floor*.

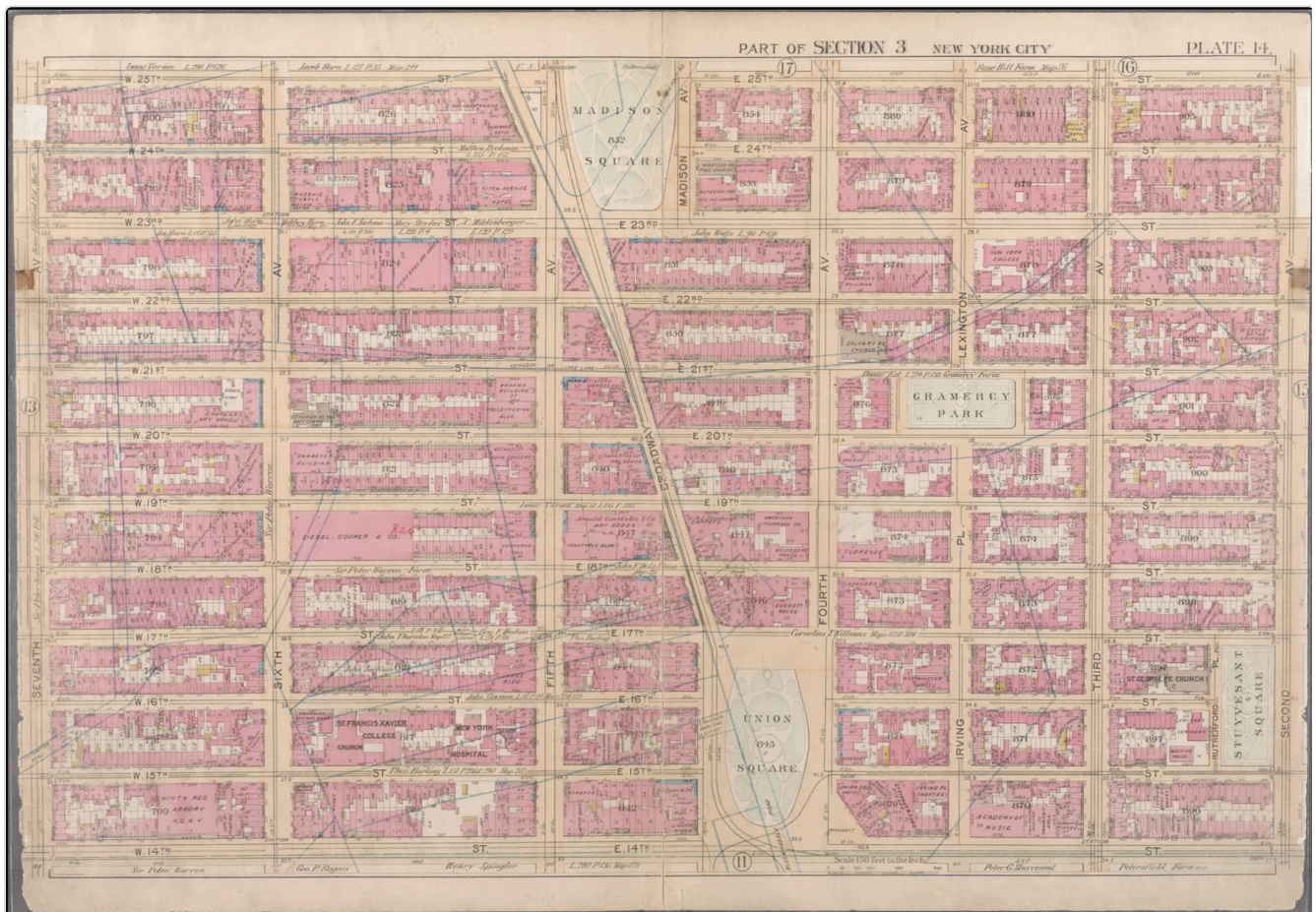
Turn right (west) on Union Square South, but stay on the park side. The building complex on the block between Fourth Avenue and Broadway comprises Circuit City, a Virgin Megastore, and a United Artists theater, plus residential apartments (Davis Brody Bond and Schuman Lichtenstein Claman & Efron, 1999). The 15 changing illuminated five-foot-high numerals display "the hours, minutes, seconds elapsed in the day; and the hours, minutes, and seconds remaining, symbolizing the city's speed, frenzy, and fragmentation." Intrinsic in the display is the astonishing multimedia sculpture of brick, concrete, steel, aluminum, gold leaf, incandescent light, steam, and sound called **Metronome** (Kristin Jones/Andrew Ginzel, 1999). A gift to New York, it is intended as a "celebration of the energy and vitality of the city." From the five-foot circle *Infinity*, steam emanates at noon and midnight, while from the 67-foot-long cone, a low tone is produced to synchronize with the plume of steam. Among other features are a five-foot rotating sphere of gold and black that mirrors the phases of the moon and *Relic*, an enlarged replica of the right hand of George Washington from the equestrian statue in the Park. Occupying the mid-block from 1870 to 1936 was the (old) **Union Square Theatre**, which survived as a converted retail store until it was demolished in 1990. 845.1

Dominating the Park entrance is the historic bronze **equestrian statue of George Washington** (Henry Kirke Brown with John Quincy Adams Ward, 1856; granite pedestal by Richard Upjohn). The statue represents Washington entering New York City on Evacuation Day, November 25, 1783, marking the end of British occupation during the Revolutionary War. The sculpture is based on an earlier Houdon bust and is considered one of the finest equestrian statues in America. It was moved from its original location at the intersection of Fourth Avenue early in the 20th century. [See engraving, page 227.]

Turn right at the Gandhi statue (described earlier) and walk north on Union Square West; note the recent attempt to re-create an “old-time” atmosphere by paving the street with Belgian blocks. At the corner of 14th Street, the **former Lincoln Building, No. 1 Union Square West** (R. H. Robertson, 1899), is a typical

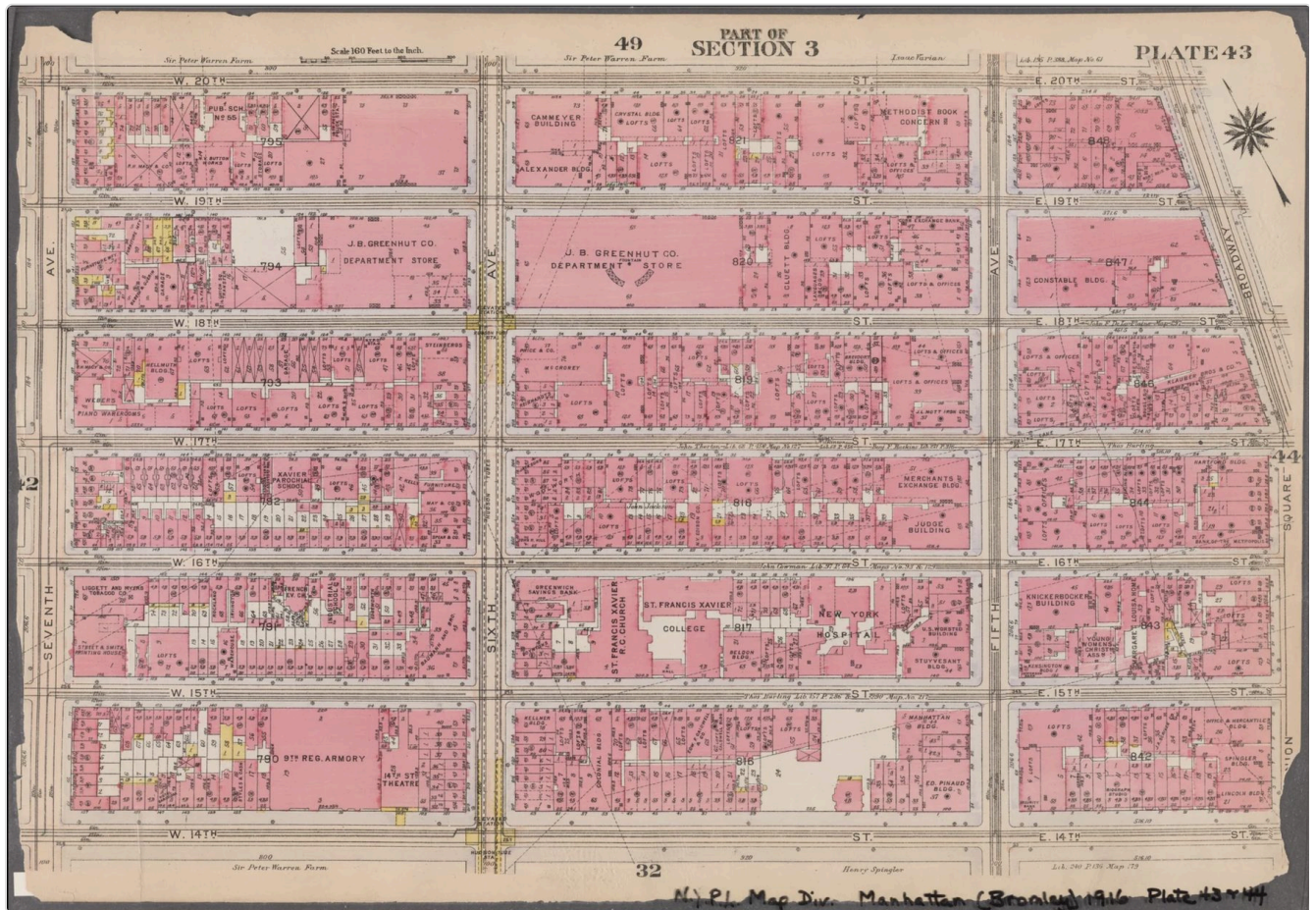
Bromley, 1897 Bromleys Atlas, p. 19

Quotes drawn from this page: 66 67



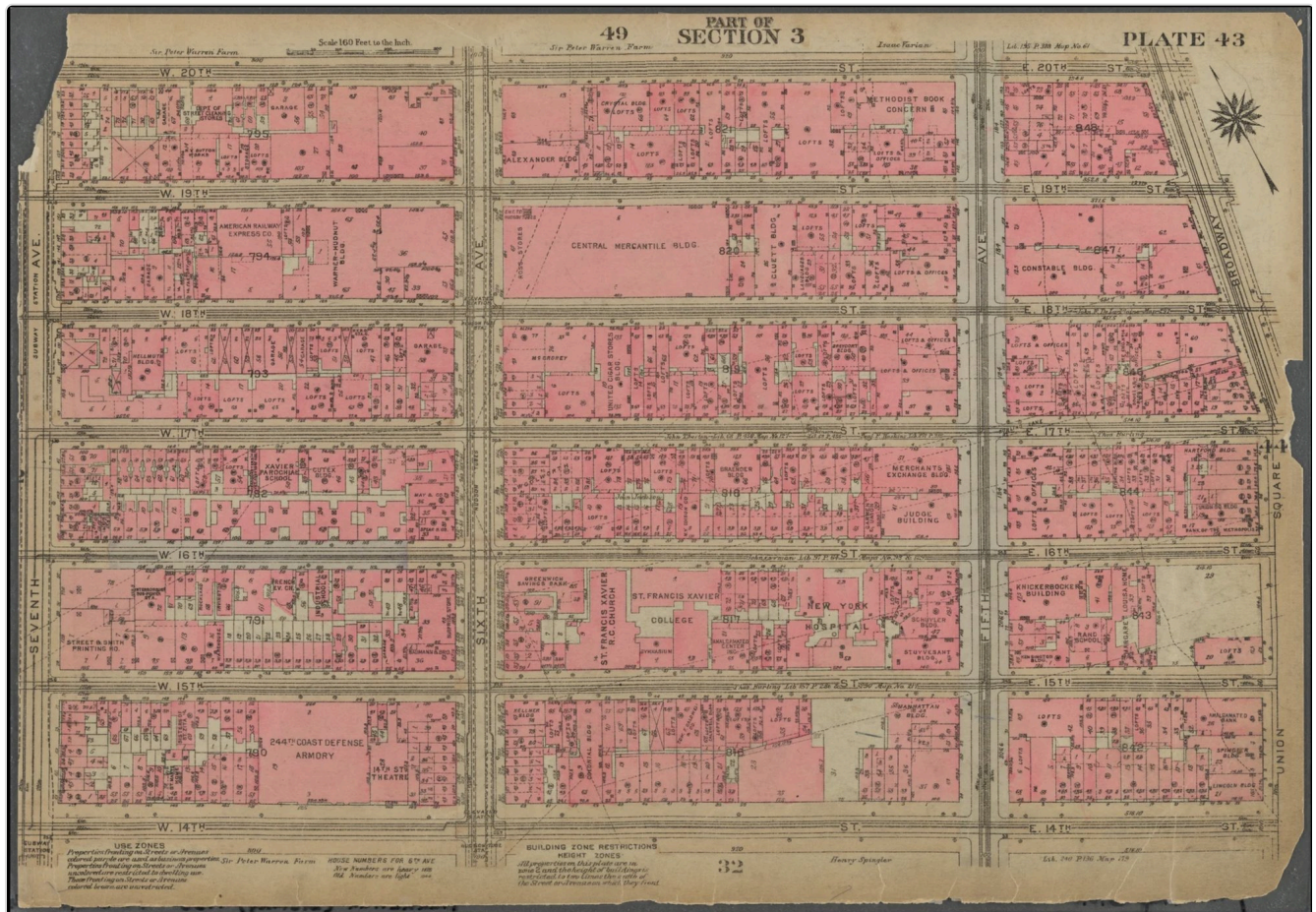
G W Bromley & Co, 1916 Atlas of the Borough of Manhattan, p. 54

Quotes drawn from this page: 68



Bromley, 1930 Land Book of the Borough of Manhattan, p. 53

Quotes drawn from this page: 69



Quotes drawn from this page: 70 71

Hennessy, *Walking Broadway*, 2020, p. 97

Quotes drawn from this page: 73 74 75 76



Plant forms are abstracted and stylized under the influence of Moorish decoration to create this lush patterning. The central tower is an Islamic extravaganza and was once topped by a minaret.

From 1967 to 1973 the sixth floor of the Decker Building housed Andy Warhol's celebrated Factory. It was here in 1968 that the artist was shot by Valerie Solanas. Warhol subsequently relocated the Factory diagonally across the street to 860 Broadway.



97

E Bank of the Metropolis

31 Union Square West

844

1903 · BRUCE PRICE

The familiar, sober classical vocabulary of bank architecture is enlivened here by a welcoming two-story bowed portico supported by a pair of gray granite Ionic columns facing Union Square. The long 16th Street elevation also features some distinctive touches. Notice the flattened arches floating in the openings of the ground level arcade and the lush foliate ornament in the panels under the windows higher up. A powerfully detailed balcony at the thirteenth story prepares the way for a bold copper cornice.

The block between 14th and 15th Streets offers two solid and accomplished historic structures: the **Spingler Building** (5 Union Square West, 1897, W. H. Hume and Sons) and the **Lincoln Building** (1 Union Square West, 1889, R. H. Robertson). The two facades share many compositional details, but one architect has chosen a classical vocabulary while the other has embraced the Romanesque.

842

More unusual is the contemporary building at 15 Union Square West. Behind the steel and glass are the arches of the cast iron facade from John Kellum's 1869 headquarters for **Tiffany & Company**. The top seven floors were added to the original five when the building was converted to condominiums in 2009.

842

Stern, *New York* 2000, 2006, p. 377

Quotes drawn from this page: 77 78



a move that was rigorously opposed by the Union Square Community Coalition, a group largely made up of newer residents who had moved into lofts and apartments and feared the impact of real estate speculation on their rented homes. Efforts to rezone Zeckendorf's site coincided with a broader reassessment of the area's zoning, which had been studied in 1979–80 by Hardy Holzman Pfeiffer Associates. Those recommendations formed the basis, in 1984, of the Department of City Planning's proposed special zoning district, intended to encourage mixed-use development on underutilized sites in the park's vicinity, especially Zeckendorf's proposed one-million-square-foot project.¹⁹ Both the district and the Zeckendorf proposal for a twenty-six-story project were approved by the City Planning Commission in November 1984 and by the Board of Estimate in January 1985.²⁰ Concerns about the fate of historic buildings on other sites around the square led to the designation as landmarks of the Lincoln Building (R. H. Robertson, 1890), 1–3 Union Square West; the Bank of the Metropolis (Bruce Price, 1903), 31 Union Square West; the Century Building (William Schickel, 1881), 33 East Seventeenth Street; the Everett Building (Starrett & Van Vleck, 1908), 45 East Seventeenth Street; and the Germania Life Insurance Company Building (D'Oench & Yost, 1911), later the Guardian Life Building, 50 Union Square East.²¹

As built, the four twenty-story towers of Zeckendorf's project, unimaginatively titled Zeckendorf Towers, contained 670 condominium apartments rising above a seven-story base housing 320,000 square feet of offices, an atrium, a much-appreciated supermarket, theaters, and underground parking. Though banal in their detailed design, the scheme of slender, salmon-colored brick-clad towers, each topped by an open-work pyramidal crown—dismissed by the editors of the *AIA Guide* as “illuminated levitating . . . yarmulkes”—minimized shadows on the square and blockage of views from it to the tower of the Consolidated Gas Company Building (Warren & Wetmore, 1926), which they were intended to complement.²² The office floors were entered from Fourth Avenue facing Union Square Park, while the apartments were entered off Fifteenth Street. In its bland uniformity and lock-step regularity, Zeckendorf Towers was hardly inspiring, but it did help the reemerging district turn the economic corner.

While most new construction in the area involved demolition of existing buildings, a through-block parcel that had been vacant since the early 1970s permitted the construction of the twelve-story Genesis Apartments (1995) for ninety-four homeless and low-income families at 113 East Thirteenth Street and an attendant 30,000-square-foot, two-story commercial building at 114 East Fourteenth Street.²³ The project was developed by Housing Enterprise for the Less Privileged (H.E.L.P.), a nonprofit organization founded by Andrew Cuomo, son of New York State Governor Mario Cuomo. As designed by Cooper, Robertson & Partners, the quietly contextual apartment building eschewed all outward signs of social engineering in favor of an expression that many would assume was intended for a much more affluent clientele. Additionally, the building's management program included a program-services staff of fifteen to help the homeless tenants, whose stay was limited to twelve months, make an adjustment back into mainstream society. Genesis provided playgrounds, a day-care center, a basketball court, a library, and a laundry room. Although many in the community were initially opposed to the project, it proved an excellent neighbor.

The retail building on Fourteenth Street, however, was not comparable in quality; its low height, a product of zoning restrictions, contributed to its suburban strip-mall character.

1 Union Square South (1998), designed by Davis, Brody & Associates in association with Schuman, Lichtenstein, Claman & Efron, a twenty-seven-story, 180-unit apartment building atop an eighty-five-foot-high mixed-use retail base that included a fourteen-screen theater, occupied the highly visible 47,500-square-foot full-block site bounded by Fourth Avenue, Thirteenth Street, Broadway, and Fourteenth Street.²⁴ In 1995 the Related Companies had acquired the site from another developer who had cleared it of its buildings, including the historic Union Square Theater (1871; rebuilt, John Terhune and Leopold Eidlitz, 1889), 58 East Fourteenth Street, which had long been obscured behind a huge McDonald's sign.²⁵

Responding to community concerns that this most prominent site might yield yet another business-as-usual apartment house banality, the developers entered into an agreement with the Municipal Art Society to select an architectural firm that would maximize the site's most important attributes, its axial relationship to the vista south along Park Avenue from Grand Central Terminal and its prominent location at the edge of Union Square Park. The society asked two dozen architects to name a firm, besides their own, that they would recommend for the job. From the responses, Related chose three firms to participate in a competition held in 1995: Davis, Brody & Associates, Robert A. M. Stern Architects, and Hardy Holzman Pfeiffer Associates, which later withdrew. Stern proposed an eighteen-story tower on a five-story stone-clad site-filling retail base. The metal-trimmed brick-clad tower was to be set back from the property line to create a strong south terminus for Park Avenue, recalling the campanile-like configuration of Warren & Wetmore's New York Central Building (1929), which, until the construction of the Pan Am Building in 1963, had concluded the axis of Park Avenue on the north side of Grand Central.

Davis, Brody's winning scheme, designed by Steven Davis, son of founding partner Lewis Davis, sought to merge the base with the tower. The initial rendering revealed stylish asymmetrical patterns of windows as well as a deep balcony cut into the north wall. But as built, its blocky mass was pretty banal, the cut reduced to virtual inconsequence, leaving the heavy aesthetic lifting to the work of the artists Kristin Jones and Andrew Ginzel. In a separate competition organized by the Public Art Fund, the two had been chosen to embellish a 100-by-60-foot wall on the building's north facade, between the commercial base and the tower. Jones and Ginzel proposed *Metronome*, confronting the street with a brick wall overlaid with an undulating wavelike pattern of concentric circles and a so-called eye, a four-foot-in-diameter opening that emitted clouds of steam, clearly upstaging the rather tepid facade of the host building. The steam, intended by the artists to recall the geothermal outpouring of Old Faithful, poured forward twice a day, at noon and at midnight, as part of the artists' intention to examine time itself. Each emission was enhanced by the sounding of a long, tapered horn intended to echo the passage of time. A digital clock on the left side of the wall augmented the frequent movements of the city by simultaneously counting and subtracting the hours of the day, with the converging digits in the middle absorbed by a blur of activity, intended to suggest the present.

